

better to have a shorter time to pay off what you owe than to become obligated to a long-term debt.

But what is that average home really worth? To determine that, assume that homes could no longer be sold using long-term mortgages. How much would the average home sell for if it could be bought with cash only? It would begin to sell for tens of thousands of dollars less. The additional cost is inflation, created through the use of long-term debt.

The longest term of debt God's people took on in the Bible was about seven years. During the year of remission (the seventh year) the Jew was instructed to release his brother from any indebtedness. "At the end of every seven years you must cancel debts. This is how it is to be done: Every creditor shall cancel the loan he has made to his fellow Israelite. He shall not require payment from his fellow Israelite or brother, because the Lord's time for canceling debts has been proclaimed" (Deuteronomy 15:1–2). Thus, the only debts that could exceed seven years were those made to non-Jews or from non-Jews.

3: *Avoid surety*

Surety is "a pledge or promise made to secure against loss, damage, or default; a security."²

The only way to avoid surety is to collateralize a loan with property that will cover the indebtedness, no matter what. Many home buyers think that because they buy an appreciating asset, such as a home, they are safe from surety, but that is not so. In most states a lender can sue to collect a deficit on a home mortgage in the event of a default. And remember that most defaults happen during a bad economy, when the prices of homes are most likely to drop, as was the case in the recession of 2008–2009.

Credit card purchases have become the most common form of surety in our generation. In this transaction one merchant sells you the material, and another finances the purchase (except for in-store credit cards). In the event of a default, the return of the